

Apex Care Hospital & Medical Center

Front Desk Receptionist Knowledge Guide

1. Facility Overview & Operating Hours

- **Outpatient Clinic Hours:** Monday–Friday: 8:00 AM – 1:00 PM and 2:00 PM – 7:30 PM. Saturday: 8:00 AM – 2:00 PM.
- **Sunday & Public Holidays:** Elective outpatient clinics are closed. Emergency, Trauma, Urgent Care, and all Inpatient units operate 24/7, 365 days a year.
- **Telehealth Hours:** Monday–Sunday, 7:00 AM – 10:00 PM for follow-ups, minor ailment triage, and lab result reviews.
- **24/7 Pharmacy:** Located in the Main Lobby, Ground Floor. Offers bedside discharge delivery and courier delivery for chronic maintenance medications.

2. Patient Registration & Intake

2.1 Identity Verification:

All patients must be registered in the EHR before medical examination. A unique Patient ID (Format: *APEX-XXXXXXX*) is assigned on first registration.

- **Required Documents:** Government-issued photo ID (Driver's License, Passport, Military ID), primary and secondary insurance cards (front & back).
- **Pediatric Patients:** Must be accompanied by a parent or legal guardian with custody documentation.
- **International Patients:** Valid passport and travel insurance guarantee of payment letter required. International Patient Relations desk coordinates embassy support.

2.2 Mandatory Intake Forms:

- **Form G-101** – General Consent for Medical Treatment.
- **Form H-202** – Medical History & Medication Reconciliation (chronic conditions, allergies, current medications).
- **Form P-303** – HIPAA Privacy Acknowledgment & Proxy Designation.
- **Form F-404** – Financial Responsibility & Assignment of Benefits (deductibles, co-pays).

3. Appointment Scheduling & Referral Policies

- **Direct Booking (No Referral Needed):** General Medicine, Family Practice, Pediatrics, Dermatology, Obstetrics & Gynecology, Preventive Wellness Exams, General Dentistry.
- **Referral Required:** Cardiology, Neurology, Oncology, Rheumatology, Endocrinology, Nephrology, Pain Management. Patient must bring a written referral from a primary care provider.
- **Slot Durations:** New Patient Consultation = 30 min | Follow-up = 15 min | Procedural Consultation = 45 min.
- **Cancellation Policy:** Patients should cancel at least 24 hours in advance for routine appointments, or 2 hours for same-day urgent slots.
- **No-Show Policy:** 1st no-show: reminder sent, no penalty. 2nd consecutive: \$25 admin fee. 3rd consecutive: booking restricted to Standby-Only mode with \$50 deposit.
- **Provider Cancellation:** Affected patients are notified within 60 minutes and offered priority rescheduling within 48 hours.

4. Patient Check-In & Late Arrival Policy

- **Two-Identifier Verification:** Always confirm Full Legal Name AND Date of Birth (or registered mobile number) before marking patient as 'Arrived'. Never state the name aloud to prompt confirmation.
- **15-Minute Grace Period:** Patients arriving within 15 minutes of their appointment keep their slot.

- **15–30 Minutes Late:** Patient moved to Standby Queue, accommodated during provider's next available buffer slot.
- **Over 30 Minutes Late:** Appointment is rescheduled unless clinical urgency is identified by triage staff.

5. Insurance Verification, Billing & Payment Policies

5.1 Accepted Insurance Plans:

Apex Care accepts: BlueCross BlueShield, Aetna, Cigna, UnitedHealthcare, Medicare Part B, New York Medicaid, and Humana.

- **Co-Pay:** Fixed dollar amount set by the insurer, collected at check-in.
- **Deductible:** Annual out-of-pocket amount before insurance cost-sharing begins.
- **Coinsurance:** Percentage of costs the patient pays after meeting their deductible.
- **TPA Cashless Pre-Authorization:** Planned inpatient surgeries require pre-auth at least 48 business hours prior. Emergency admissions: pre-auth initiated within 4 hours of bed assignment.

5.2 Financial Hardship & Payment Options:

- **Zero-Interest Payment Plans:** Uninsured patients or self-pay balances over \$500 qualify for 6–24 month installment plans under the Apex Community Health Assistance Program.
- **Good Faith Estimate (GFE):** Uninsured/self-pay patients have the legal right to a written GFE of expected charges before scheduled treatment (No Surprises Act).
- **Accepted Payment Methods:** Visa, MasterCard, Amex, Discover, Apple Pay, Google Pay, HSA/FSA Debit Cards, Cashier's Checks, and Cash.

6. Diagnostic Test Preparation – Patient Instructions

Receptionists provide the following preparation instructions when patients ask about upcoming tests:

Test / Procedure	Patient Preparation	Key Restrictions
Fasting Blood Glucose & Lipid Panel	Water-only fast for 10–12 hours before the blood draw.	No coffee, tea, juice, gum, or tobacco. Morning BP medication allowed with a sip of water.
Abdominal Ultrasound	Fast 6–8 hours prior. Avoid fatty foods the night before.	Small sips of water allowed. No carbonated drinks.
Pelvic / Obstetric Ultrasound	Drink 1.0–1.2 liters of water 1 hour before appointment.	Do NOT empty bladder before the scan.
MRI Scan	Wear loose, metal-free clothing. No fasting needed (unless abdominal MRI).	Inform staff of pacemakers, metal implants, or cochlear devices.
Mammography	Best scheduled 7–10 days after menstrual cycle onset.	No deodorant, powder, or lotion on underarms/chest on exam day.
CT Scan (with IV Contrast)	Fast 4 hours prior. Creatinine test required (within 30 days).	Metformin must be withheld 48 hours post-contrast if prescribed.
Upper Endoscopy / Colonoscopy	Endoscopy: 8h fast. Colonoscopy: clear liquids 24h + full bowel prep.	Must be accompanied by a responsible adult driver home.

7. Medical Records & Report Turnaround Times

- **Routine Blood Tests (CBC, CMP, Lipids, Urinalysis):** Same-day results by 5:00 PM if collected before 11:30 AM.
- **Hormone & Thyroid Panels:** 24–36 hours.

- **X-Ray & Routine Ultrasound:** Radiologist report within 24 business hours.
- **MRI, CT & Nuclear Scans:** Report within 48–72 hours.
- **Digital Portal:** All reports and clinical notes auto-uploaded to *apexcare.health/portal*.
- **Releasing Records:** Requires signed Form R-10 (HIPAA Authorization). Standard processing: 3–5 business days. Urgent hospital transfers: within 4 hours.

8. Inpatient Admissions, Visiting Hours & Discharge

8.1 Admission Process:

- **Elective Admissions:** Patient reports to Inpatient Admission Desk with physician's admission order, photo ID, and insurance pre-authorization approval.
- **Self-Pay Deposits:** General Ward: \$1,000 | Private Room: \$2,500 | ICU: \$5,000 — collected at admission, reconciled at discharge.

8.2 Visiting Hours:

- **General Wards:** 10:00 AM – 1:00 PM and 4:00 PM – 8:00 PM. Max 2 visitors at a time.
- **ICU / CCU / NICU:** 11:00 AM – 12:00 PM and 5:00 PM – 6:00 PM. Max 1 immediate adult family member. Hand hygiene, gown, and mask required.
- **NICU & Pediatric Units:** Parents and legal guardians have 24/7 access with Guardian Security Pass.
- **Maternity / Labor & Delivery:** One birth partner 24/7; general family visitors 2:00 PM – 7:00 PM.
- **Children Under 12:** Not permitted in inpatient units or ICUs.
- **Discharge Checkout:** Standard checkout by 12:00 Noon. Discharges after 2:00 PM incur a half-day room charge.

9. HIPAA Privacy & Front Desk Conduct

- **Quiet Voice:** Never announce a patient's diagnosis, specialty, room number, or test aloud in the waiting area.
- **Sign-In Sheets:** Record only name, arrival time, and provider. Never write medical reason for visit or symptoms.
- **Screen Security:** Monitors facing public areas must use privacy filters. Workstations auto-lock after 60 seconds of inactivity.
- **Phone Messages:** Leave only hospital name, receptionist name, and callback number. Never mention diagnoses, test names, or specialist types on voicemail.
- **Privacy Breach:** Any suspected PHI disclosure must be reported to the Hospital Privacy Officer within 1 hour.

10. Patient Rights & Accessibility Services

- **Right to Informed Consent:** Patients receive full explanation of procedures, risks, and alternatives in plain language before agreeing to any treatment.
- **Right to Refuse:** Patients may decline any test or procedure after understanding clinical consequences.
- **Grievance Filing:** Patients may submit complaints to the Patient Ombudsman at *advocacy@apexcare.health*. Written response within 7 business days.
- **Language Interpretation:** Free 24/7 medical interpretation in 40+ languages (Spanish, Mandarin, Arabic, Hindi, French, etc.) via video/phone terminals.
- **ASL & Braille:** Certified ASL video interpreters available 24/7. Braille signage and large-print forms on request.
- **Service Animals:** Certified service dogs permitted in all public and outpatient areas (ADA Title III).

11. Emergency Escalation & Scope of Practice

IMPORTANT – Non-Clinical Boundary: Receptionists and AI voice agents must never diagnose illnesses, interpret lab values, assess whether symptoms are dangerous, adjust medications, or recommend home remedies.

If a caller or patient describes any of the following, immediately direct them to Emergency (Ext 911 / 999) or advise calling 911:

- Chest pain, pressure, or tightness radiating to jaw, neck, or arm.
- Stroke symptoms: Face drooping, Arm weakness, Speech difficulty (FAST).
- Severe sudden shortness of breath or blue lips/fingers.
- Worst headache of their life, or sudden vision loss.
- Suspected poisoning or drug overdose.
- Active suicidal ideation or violent behavior.

Administrative Escalations:

- Billing disputes → Senior Patient Billing Advocate.
- Aggressive or abusive visitors → Hospital Security Control Room.
- Clinical complaints / malpractice concerns → Patient Relations Ombudsman.
- Media inquiries / VIP patients → Public Relations & Hospital Administration.

12. Patient Communication & De-Escalation (LAST Model)

Apply the **LAST** framework during difficult patient interactions:

1. **L – Listen:** Let the patient explain fully without interruption.
2. **A – Apologize:** Acknowledge empathetically: *'I understand how stressful this must be — let me help you right away.'*
3. **S – Solve:** Provide concrete help: *'Let me check your queue status with clinical staff immediately.'*
4. **T – Thank:** Close with courtesy: *'Thank you for your patience while we ensure everyone receives safe, thorough care.'*

13. Facility Amenities & Campus Information

- **Smoke-Free Campus:** Tobacco, e-cigarettes, and cannabis are strictly prohibited in all indoor and outdoor hospital areas.
- **Parking:** Multi-level garage at \$3.00/hour. Free validation at registration for appointments over 1 hour, chemotherapy, dialysis, or day surgeries.
- **Valet Parking:** Available at Main Entrance, Monday–Friday 6:30 AM – 8:00 PM.
- **Wheelchair Assistance:** Complimentary wheelchairs and escort available at all entrance drop-off zones.
- **Prayer & Quiet Room:** Multi-faith sanctuary on Ground Floor West Wing, open 24/7. Chaplain services on call.
- **Photography Ban:** Photography and recording prohibited in clinical areas, waiting lounges, and ICU corridors.

14. Telehealth & Virtual Consultations

- **Eligible for Telehealth:** Chronic disease follow-ups (stable Hypertension, Diabetes), lab result reviews, dermatology image evaluations, nutritional counseling, mild upper respiratory triage.
- **Must Be In-Person:** Acute chest pain, shortness of breath, severe abdominal pain, trauma, fractures, physical examination needs, or first-time controlled substance prescriptions.
- **Technical Requirements:** Encrypted video via ApexCare App. Government photo ID shown on screen during virtual check-in. Sessions cannot be recorded without bilateral written consent.